A Light in the Darkness

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52035247.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by Ogjnogth

Summary

"Adora stared at the assignment she really should have started two weeks ago. She was… anxious? Like, the paper was due on Friday, it was Wednesday afternoon, it needed to be several pages long, it was assigned two weeks ago, she hadn't started, how could she not be. And yet…"

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Adora stared at the assignment she really should have started two weeks ago. She was… anxious? Like, the paper was due on Friday, it was Wednesday afternoon, it needed to be several pages long, it was assigned two weeks ago, she hadn't started, how could she not be. And yet…

Adora groaned into her hands. In high school, even at her worst bouts of senioritis, she would have been panicking trying to pass something decent in at this point. Yet here she was, sitting alone in the library, staring at her computer screen, barely able to think about the thing. If she really put in the effort, she might manage to create a Google Doc and stare at it for another hour. Maybe that'd help her will herself to write the paper.

She chuckled humorlessly to herself. Yeah, right— and then she'd raise her magic sword and say "For the honor of Grayskull", transforming into She-Ra, Princess of Power, and turning her old stuffed pony from when she was little, Swift Wind, into a rainbow alicorn mount that spoke English.

Adora looked at her phone's clock despite the fact that her laptop very much had one in the corner. 4:30. Wow. She managed to waste time not writing a paper the entire time Catra was at her Bio lab.

She shut her laptop and stood up from the table— she wasn't gonna write the paper tonight. Maybe tomorrow. She had a short day, Catra had her Chem lab. She had plenty of time!

… Adora didn't even believe her own thoughts. This paper was not getting written.

Really, there was no reason Adora should be having difficulty here. Nothing in her classes wasn't doable. She was in AP classes, got into her first choice college BMU with a great scholarship, was dorming with her girlfriend to finally get away from her loving but somewhat overwhelming family. Hell, her life was basically perfect — she had gotten together with her lifelong best friend after,

according to Glimmer and Bow, “a decade of useless mutual pining”. She had loved Catra for as long as she could remember, and then come senior prom, the brunette asked her to be her date.

Yet here she was, unable to even begin the very same kind of paper she wrote like five times last year alone.

Apparently she was lost in thought so long that she had made it all the way back to her and Catra’s dorm through pure muscle memory. She pulled out her ID, booping the electronic lock, and turned the handle, ready to fall into bed after a long day of sitting around doing absolutely nothing.

Walking into the room, she saw Catra, dressed in a her fluffy cat onesie, curled up on their (technically Adora’s but she almost never actually used her own) bed, scrolling Twitter while wearing her headphones turned up far too high, listening to what Adora could only assume was the loudest, angriest music ever crafted by humankind. Adora instantly felt her mood lighten, and a loving smile appeared on her face. Even when she was having a shitty day and couldn’t make herself do anything productive, the tiny girl was always able to make her happy.

Eventually Catra noticed her girlfriend, and turned to her, headphones still blaring horrific noises apparently created by a human voice.

“Hey Adora,” Catra greeted, voice thick with tiredness.

“Hey Cat.” Adora sat down on the bed next to her girlfriend, kissing her on the forehead and pulling her into a tight cuddle. “How was your lab?”

Catra then went into a long monologue about her day— talking about interesting things from class, annoying people, generally being tired, her klutz of a lab partner… eventually Adora stopped really listening, just taking in Catra, leaning into the shorter girl,

playing with her hair, letting herself ease the ambient anxiety that she could never seem to rid herself of these days.

Clearly she had zoned out for awhile, because she heard Catra's voice cut into her thoughts, her look expectant.

"Sorry, I zoned out. What did you say?"

Catra gave a loving, understanding look, before repeating: "How're you doing with your paper?"

Adora gulped nervously before lying through her teeth, "Coming along. Gonna put the finishing touches on it tomorrow." Well, technically not a lie—everyone knows she was biologically incapable of telling a convincing lie— just her signature non-answer. The way she used "coming along", it could mean anywhere between "I need ten more minutes" and "I've been procrastinating this whole time and haven't started". Plus, if everything went smoothly by some miracle, she would in fact "put the finishing touches on it tomorrow".

If Catra picked up on Adora's nervousness, she didn't show it. "If you want me to proofread, I can. Not that I'm terribly acquainted with 'American Gothic' literature, but I could help tighten up some writing."

"No!" Okay, way too forceful. Suspiciously so. "No, you have so much on your plate already. I don't wanna make you have to do more than you already do." That felt better. Could easily be mistaken for the blonde being her annoyingly selfless self. Plus, Catra had been valedictorian in high school— she had been confident with the absolutely stuffed schedule she had this semester.

Thankfully, Catra wasn't putting up much fight. With a yawn, she said, "True. Right now I just wanna watch Netflix and cuddle with my girlfriend."

Adora couldn't even remember the plot of whatever show Catra put on on her computer. Probably just a silly rom com or

something. She had just gone back to zoning out, taking in her girlfriend and playing with her dark curls, as Catra actually watched, occasionally shooting loving glances to the blonde.

“Adora?”

The blonde very suddenly snapped back to reality, immediately noticing that the movie was over (really? Already?) and Catra was staring at her, heterochromatic gaze full of loving concern.

Noticing that Adora was back to reality, Catra cautiously asked, “Hey, are you okay?”

“Yeah, I’m okay. Why?” Adora’s words rang extremely hollowly to herself.

Catra glanced away before speaking. “You’ve just seemed a little distant, lately. Not really yourself.”

She paused, biting her lip, “Your load
isn’t too much, is it? You just seem exhausted all the time.”

“I…” Adora paused before she could say anything. What was she even supposed to say?

“True,” Catra chuckled. “You’d think that AP would help with the whole thing, but I guess high schools can’t really replicate meeting twice a week for an hour and a half. Not without fucking with everyone’s schedules.”

The short brunette stared softly into Adora’s eyes. “But seriously. If you need help, I’m here. Doesn’t matter what I’m doing. You’re more important to me.”

“I know. I’m okay. Just tired.” It was like a mantra at this point. She was just tired and procrastinating. It was the truth, so why did it feel so ingenuine?

“Promise you’ll tell me if it changes?”

“I promise,” Adora swore half-heartedly. She knew herself, after all.

Catra leaned in, pulled the blonde in to a blissful kiss, and for a second nothing mattered but Catra. Eventually they pulled back, panting for breath, overwhelmed in each other’s love.

“Hey Adora?” Catra asked timidly, “Would you mind running downstairs and grabbing some food from the cafeteria? I was gonna get dinner and bring it up but I forgot, and now I’m too comfy.”

Adora couldn’t help but smile. Her girlfriend loved her creature comforts. She leaned down to kiss Catra on the forehead before quickly hurrying out of the dorm, focusing on the task at hand, rather than the one that was assigned two weeks ago.

—

Two Days Later:

Adora stood in front of the bathroom mirror, leaning and trying to calm her nerves.

Not that she should have any, really. She didn’t have to pass in that paper she didn’t write.

Not if she bailed on the class.

She leaned her head down to the hard marble sinktop. The cool helped.

She wanted to vomit.

Hell, she had tried, to no avail.

She looked at the clock on her phone. 1:45. Class should be out by now. If she went out now, headed back to the dorm, nothing would look amiss.

She grabbed her coat and bag she left in the caf and sauntered up the stairs. Only one flight, so it never took long, but walked as slowly as the foot traffic could allow.

Catra was right by the building entrance, holding a tray of drinks from Dunkins.

"Hey, Adora!"

The blonde rushed over to her girlfriend. "Hey Cat! I thought you had class now?"

"Professor called today off. Had to go to a wedding," Catra chuckled. "So I grabbed coffee, and your stupid slushie."

"Hey! Meanie," Adora swiped her tall white beverage from the tray, "coolattas are amazing."

"In the summer maybe. I don't understand how you can drink them, like, in January. Especially with your basic vanilla flavor." She leaned over to give the blonde a peck on the cheek. "Anyway, guess the universe wanted to reward you for your work."

And with those words Adora's blood ran cold.

"Yeah," Adora nodded emptily, "nice to get it off my chest."

"C'mon. Lets get out of here. It's finally Friday, classes are done for the week. Wander the city a bit?" The brunette smiled softly at her girlfriend.

"Sounds great!" Adora clasped her girlfriend's hand, sipping her icy drink, trying not to focus on the haunting anxiety of the paper she failed to write

Everything was going to be fine.

End Notes

Disembodied narrator voice
Everything was not, in n fact, going to be fine.

Also, Adora canonically cannot lie, but like neither can I.
Doesn't stop me from finding loopholes.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!